Jim Partridge, 1980 wet-turned heart wood holly (*Ilex spp.*) bowl

Parnham House in Dorset. Richard Raffan had cajoled John into this after visiting one of the Worshipful Company of Turners' competitions in the late 1970s, on the basis that the standard of work was so poor that something needed to be done to put a bomb under UK turning. It is fair to say it may not have revolutionised UK turning, but it certainly made everyone look at what they were doing in a different light. Things gradually improved and much fruit was borne in time.

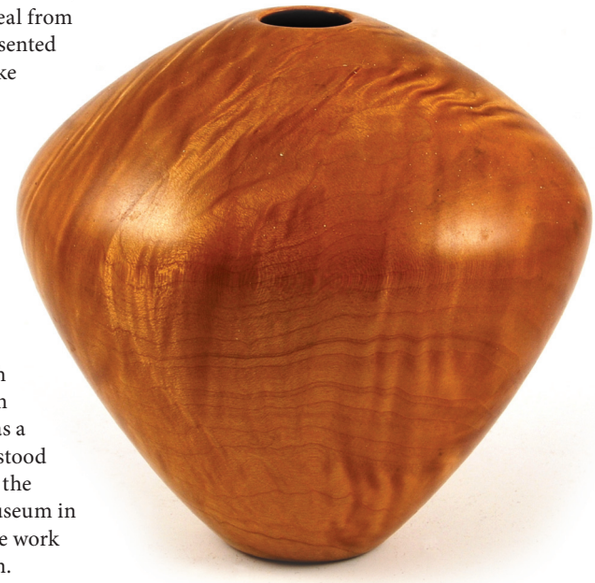
This seminar was the catalyst for Don White to become a full-time turner. Ciaran Forbes and Liam O'Neill came over from Ireland and in time they had a great influence on turning in Ireland. Liam was the driving force for the formation of the Irish Woodturners Guild and both became internationally known through their work. Lots of seeds were planted that weekend.

One thing that couldn't have been foreseen at the time was that without this event the AWGB may never have come into being. The format of this seminar was very different from what happens today: it was very formal, with the first day being dedicated to slide presentations and lectures, with quite a line up that awakened us all. Edward Lucie Smith, the art critic, was in the chair. Presentations were made by David Ellsworth, Bob Stocksdale, Stephen Hogbin, Frank Knox and Paul Smith from the USA and Canada, plus Richard Raffan and Neville Neal from the UK. Ellsworth and Hogbin presented work that made us all sit up and take notice: Ellsworth pioneered thin walled vessels hollowed through a ridiculous small hole, Hogbin cut apart and reassembled (his 1980 publication *Woodturning: The Purpose of the Object* was cutting edge at the time). Both of their presentations were revolutionary to a UK audience. Stocksdale was probably the best-known bowl turner in the world at the time with his porcelain thin bowls made from spectacular woods. Frank Knox was a fine ornamental turner who understood the word restraint. Paul Smith was the Director of the American Craft Museum in New York and opened eyes with the work shown from the museum collection.

Our comfort zone was restored by Richard Raffan and Neville Neal, both presenting what we in the UK were more used to. Richard described his philosophy of making work for use; Neville was probably the UK's leading ladderback chair maker at the time.

The second day was very different: all demonstrations (no seating, just stand, look and listen) plus discussion groups.

I mentioned earlier there might never have been an AWGB without this event; Margaret Lester was the organising administrator. I was attending a James Krenov seminar when Margaret came and sat next to me. She said, "You're a woodturner aren't you?" and then explained about the planned 1980 event. She said she knew nothing about lathes or any of the technical side of things, so asked if she could she phone me for advice. She leaned quite heavily on me during the planning. Through this I got to know her well and her meticulous planning, so I convinced her to be the organising administrator of the Loughborough Seminar in 1987, where the AWGB was formed. ●



David Ellsworth, 1981 figured maple (*Acer spp.*) hollow vessel

PROFILE: RAY KEY

My interest in wood can probably be traced back to when I was around four or five years old. My father was always working with wood, but a German prisoner of war who my parents befriended probably sparked my real interest. I still have a three-legged stool and a leather jointed pull-along dog that he made before he was repatriated. Soon after his return to Germany in 1948, he sent a turned wood chess set. Was it this that sparked my love of turning?

My first experience of seeing anyone turn was when I was about 10 years old; the man in question was a wonderful character by the name of Charlie Gardener. He and his wife used to be invited to the Royal Show and Chelsea Flower Show. His wife showed off their collection of gypsy caravans which she restored. Charlie turned mostly egg cups on a lathe cobbled together on a Singer sewing machine base, which had a Daff car gearbox to change speed with. I got to know them both well over the years.

I first turned at school aged 14, making a handle for a garden fork I had created in the metal shop. In 1958 I became an apprentice Pattern Maker and turning was part of the job, I turned a lot, on a lathe from the ark, flat belt drive with slipping clutch. I have always said Pattern Makers don't turn they scrape; there is a good reason as they work to very fine limits.

In 1965 I purchased my first lathe, met my wife-to-be and started a new job in Chrysler Styling Studios. The lathe kept me sane during my eight years there. I used the lathe to make a lot of our furniture and I also started supplying shops across the Cotswolds with domestic useful turned wood products. By 1973, either the day job or the hobby had to go. With the full backing of my wife Liz, the day job went. Her question to me was, 'do you still think you will be wanting to do this in seven years time?'. That was 42 years ago; the rest is history, as they say.

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